

MANISH RAJPUT

DEPUTY, FOR NOW
DKS leaves party president Kharge's residence after a meeting, May 17

DKS'S ACHILLES HEEL IS A BUNCH OF I-T AND MONEY-LAUNDERING CASES, WHICH HE MAINTAINS ARE **A RESULT OF LOCKING HORNS WITH THE BJP IN THE PAST**

document had noted. Incidentally, while outgo on salaries is set to increase when the 7th Pay Commission pay scales are implemented, at least 258,000 government posts—a third of the total 769,000 in Karnataka—were lying vacant as of December.

The state's revenue collections have seen a robust recovery post-Covid, registering 17 per cent year-on-year growth up to January 2023 due to a revival in private consumption and capital formation. "If there is more revenue, this is the time to reduce subsidies, look at areas of investment that provide proper livelihoods to people. Their earnings must go up," says Dr A. Ravindra, former Karnataka chief secretary.

"When the power sector is already under considerable fiscal pressure, announcing further subsidies just bleeds the budget. Unless you have alternative sources of revenue coming in to meet that cost, somebody has to pay for it," says retired bureaucrat G. Gurucharan, who last year carried out a comprehensive study of the power sector for the Karnataka government. Power sector reforms are crucial—currently,

BUMPY ROAD AHEAD

↘ THE '5 GUARANTEES': Karnataka already spends Rs 31,367 cr. annually on subsidies. With the additional expenditure required for the '5 guarantees', managing state finances will become a challenge

↘ FILLING UP GOVT VACANCIES: The party has promised to fill up vacancies in all departments in a year. A third of the total 769,000 govt jobs are lying vacant

↘ REVISITING OBC RESERVATION: The poll manifesto promises to increase the reservation ceiling from 50 per cent to 75 per cent. This includes restoring the 4 per cent Muslim reservation and hiking reservation for other OBC groups

↘ CASTE CENSUS: The party has promised to release the socio-economic caste survey done during the previous Siddaramaiah term (2013-18). The contentious census has been in cold storage

↘ OLD PENSION SCHEME: The manifesto promises to 'sympathetically consider' extension of OPS to pensionable staff who joined service after 2006

↘ STATE EDUCATION POLICY: The poll manifesto promises to reject the National Education Policy and implement a State Education Policy

↘ FIXING BENGALURU: It promises to enact a comprehensive legislation exclusively for the management of municipal corporation Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike, bringing all utilities under a single agency. Also, to create a mega 'Bengaluru Region'